

The Galápagos Islands



THE LONELY GALÁPAGOS ISLANDS, which lie in the Pacific Ocean, west of South America, are like nowhere else on Earth. An extraordinary variety of birds live among the dry cactus scrub and jagged volcanic rocks, and many of them are found only on these islands. There

are two main reasons why the bird life of the Galápagos Islands is so unique. Firstly, the islands are so far from the mainland of South America that only a few birds have managed to reach them. These were able to develop into a variety of species because there was little competition for food and nesting places. Secondly, warm waters from the Pacific and cool waters from the Antarctic both flow past the islands. This means that birds usually found in cold places, such as penguins and albatrosses, live side-by-side with tropical species, such as flamingos and frigate birds.

Flightless cormorant
(*Nannopterum harrisi*)
Length: 3 ft 3 in (1 m)



They nest on rocks close to the sea.

DARWIN'S FINCHES

The 18 different species of Galápagos finch look similar because they probably originated from one species. But each species has a different shaped bill to eat a different food. The British naturalist Charles Darwin's studies of these birds helped him develop his theory of evolution. This explains how plants and animals may have changed over many generations to suit their particular habitat.



Charles Darwin
1809–1882



Gray warbler-finch
(*Certhidea fusca*)
This finch has a fine, pointed bill for catching small insects.

Small tree finch
(*Geospiza parvula*)
The tree finch has a thicker bill to cope with fruit, buds, small seeds, and insects.

Large ground finch
(*Geospiza magnirostris*)
This large ground finch has a heavy, strong bill for crushing seeds.

Woodpecker finch
(*Geospiza pallida*)
This is one of the few birds to make and use a tool. It uses a twig as a tool to find insect grubs under bark and tease them out.

Galápagos penguin

This rare penguin is able to live so near the equator because of the cool waters of the Humboldt Current, which flow past the Galápagos Islands. It feeds on fish and nests in small groups, laying its eggs in nests of stones, in caves, or in holes. It has flipper-like wings, webbed feet, and a streamlined body shape, which make it a very strong swimmer, but it is clumsy on land. It hops shakily from one rock to another, holding out its little flippers for balance. When it reaches the water, it jumps in feet first.



Strong flippers help the penguin "fly" underwater.

Galápagos penguin
(*Spheniscus mendiculus*)
Length: 1 ft 8 in (53 cm)

